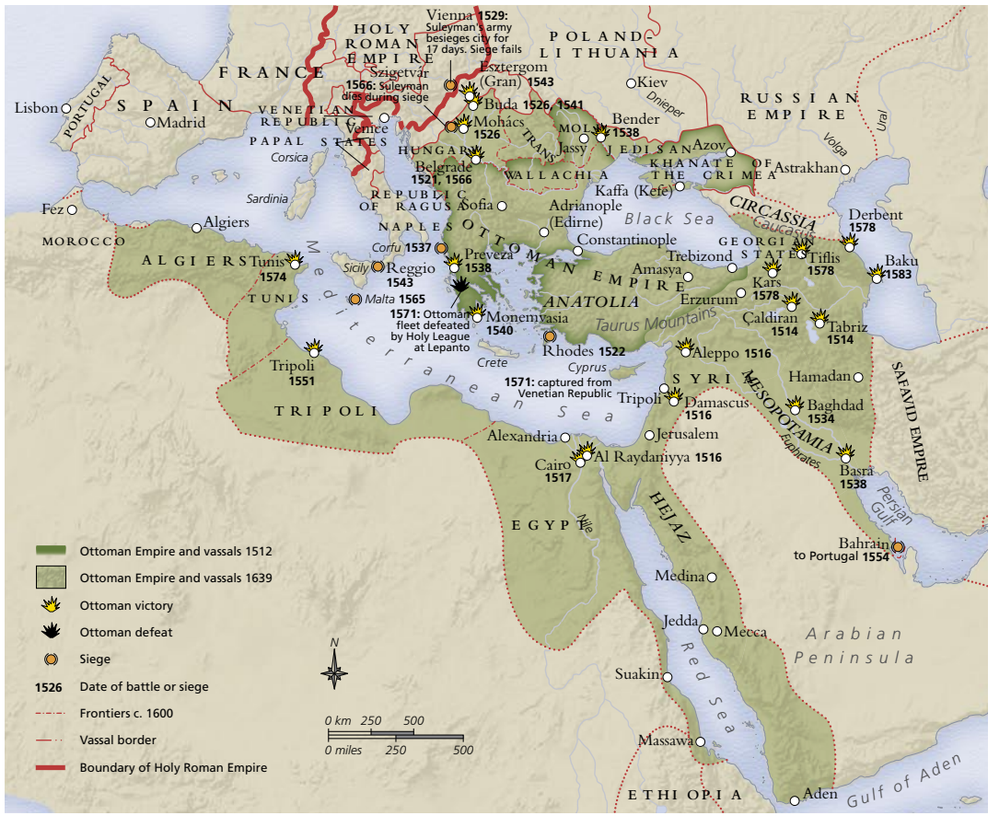


Ottoman expansion
In the course of 150 years, the Ottoman Turks grew from a small band of holy warriors, settled on land in northwest Anatolia, into rulers of an empire straddling Europe and Asia. The scale of their expansion, as illustrated, is extraordinary. They won almost 20 key battles in the 16th century alone, but by the end of the 17th century their empire was in decline.

drunken and disruptive than was common amongst their contemporaries in the Christian world. Their highly decorated weaponry and noisy military band gave the Ottoman forces an air of great splendour, but they were thoroughly practical fighting men skilled in the deployment of their different arms and capable of disciplined battlefield manoeuvres. In comparison to this efficiency, their enemies often seemed fatally naïve. At Nicopolis, for example, in 1396, a body of Christian crusader knights launched a hasty cavalry charge against an army led by sultan Bayezid without first establishing the size or disposition of the Ottoman forces. After scattering the "*azabs*", who had been placed in forward positions as sacrificial pawns, the knights found themselves exposed to a counterattack by Bayezid's far more numerous cavalry and were duly massacred. At Mohacs 130 years later, Christian knights suffered a similar fate on a battlefield where gunpowder weapons were present. Facing the usual enthusiastic charge by armoured Christian knights, the Ottoman *sipahis* feigned flight, drawing the knights straight into the devastating fire of artillery and of disciplined ranks of janissaries armed with arquebuses. Also harassed by the flanking attacks of the Ottoman light cavalry, the knights were finally swept away by a counter-charge launched by the sultan's heavy cavalry armed with swords and spears.

The Ottomans were equally successful against Muslim opponents. Their defeat of the Egyptian Mamluks at Marj Dabik, in Syria, in 1516 owed much to the possession of gunpowder weapons, which the Egyptians did not have. When the Mamluks deployed their own hastily assembled cannon at Raydaniya in Egypt the following year, they were nonetheless defeated again, the skilful Ottoman cavalry executing nimble flanking attacks that nullified the firepower of the Egyptian forces.



Ottoman drums
Janissaries are shown here with the drums that were used to urge soldiers into battle. Janissaries lived in their barracks and served as policemen and firefighters in peacetime.

FAIR-WEATHER FIGHTERS

If the Ottoman army had a major weakness, it was the sheer numbers of its soldiers and horses. With only limited logistic support, this host had mostly to live off the country and could not survive a winter on campaign in central Europe. Thus when Suleyman the Magnificent (ruled 1520-66) put Vienna, the capital of the Habsburg Empire, under siege in 1529, he had to withdraw after only a month in order to have time to complete the long march back to Constantinople before the weather worsened. In the European theatre, the Ottoman forces were only a summer army.

DECLINE AND FALL

Through the 17th and 18th centuries the Ottoman army gradually fell into a decadence that reflected problems experienced by the whole of Ottoman society. There was a failure to keep up with technological advances that were prevalent throughout Western European and a declining economy that undermined the resources available for military campaigns. The *timar* system began to decay and was eventually abandoned.

Especially sad was the fate of the janissaries. During the 17th century they ceased to be slaves recruited by the *devshirme*, instead being drawn from free-born Muslims eager to join a privileged military set. The janissary corps swelled in numbers, from around 20,000 at the time of Suleyman to well in excess of 100,000 by the end of the 18th century. This bloated body ceased to have any effective military function, degenerating into a pampered social elite and blocking efforts to reform and modernize the armed forces. It was finally suppressed, with considerable bloodshed, in 1826 – known as "The Auspicious Incident". By then Ottoman Turkey had declined, now little more than a ramshackle military power clinging precariously to the remains of its empire.